# Activity 8 — Service Recovery Under Pressure — The Wedding Catering Failure

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| **Topic** | 8 — Recovering Difficult Customers |
| **Mapping** | LO2 · Apply HEARD/LAST de-escalation, establish common ground and set limits professionally. |
| **Format** | Role Play + Case Study |
| **Duration** | 15 minutes |
| **Roles** | Pairs or trios. A = Duty Manager, B = Mr Wong, C = observer scoring against HEARD. |

## The Scenario

You are the Duty Manager for a Singapore catering company. Yesterday you catered a 200-guest wedding at a hotel ballroom in Novena. Three failures occurred: the vegetarian main course (40 portions, pre-ordered and confirmed in writing) was never loaded onto the truck; service started 35 minutes late; and the wedding cake was delivered with visible damage to one side.

The bride's father, Mr Wong, paid S$18,400. He is in your office now. He has photographs. He has already posted a one-star review naming your company. He is demanding a full refund and says he will 'make sure nobody in Singapore uses you again'.

What you know internally: the vegetarian order WAS in the system — the kitchen printed the run sheet before the final amendment was saved, a known gap flagged twice by kitchen staff and never fixed. Your authority extends to a 40% refund; anything beyond that needs the Director, who is contactable.

You cannot un-ruin the wedding. That is the constraint you are working inside.

## What You Will Produce

A full recovery conversation applying HEARD, plus a written root-cause fix for the run-sheet gap.

*Materials: HEARD framework card · LAST framework card · Observer scoring sheet.*

## Discussion Questions

1. Apply HEARD to this case. Write what you would actually SAY at each of the five stages.

2. You cannot undo the wedding. What are you actually recovering, and is recovery even possible here?


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3. Mr Wong demands a full refund; you can authorise 40%. How do you set that limit without sounding like you are haggling over his daughter's wedding?

4. The kitchen flagged the run-sheet gap twice and nothing was done. Do you tell Mr Wong that? Argue both sides.

5. Perceived justice has three parts — outcome, process and treatment. Which of the three can you still influence here?

6. Design the process fix. What exactly changes so this cannot happen to the next customer?

## Step-by-Step

1. Brief the roles separately. B (Mr Wong) must open by placing the photographs down and must NOT accept the first offer. B is devastated and angry, but not abusive — this is recovery practice, not escalation practice.

2. A prepares for 2 minutes using the HEARD card. Write one opening sentence for each of the five stages before starting. Do not improvise the apology.

3. Begin. A must let B speak completely — including the review threat — before saying anything beyond acknowledgement sounds. Observer times this; interrupting inside the first 90 seconds is the most common failure.

4. A empathises by naming the specific loss: the vegetarian guests who had nothing to eat, the 35-minute delay in front of 200 people, the cake in the photographs. Generic phrases like 'I understand your frustration' score zero here.

5. A apologises unconditionally. No 'if you were disappointed', no 'but the kitchen', no policy citation. One clean sentence taking ownership.

6. A resolves: state the 40% refund as immediate and already authorised, and state that you are taking the balance to the Director today. Give a specific callback time.

7. A establishes common ground before setting the limit: 'we both want this made right' — then set the limit calmly and once. Do not repeat or defend it if B pushes; restate the escalation path instead.

8. A diagnoses aloud: explain that a process gap let the amended order miss the run sheet, and that it is being closed. Decide as a pair how much detail to disclose — you will defend that choice in the debrief.

9. Observer scores each HEARD stage present/absent, times the first interruption, and notes whether the apology contained any conditional word ('if', 'but', 'however').

10. After the role play, both partners write the process fix together: the specific system or procedural change, its owner, and how Mr Wong will be told about it.


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11. Swap roles and rerun with a different disclosure decision, so both learners experience receiving the recovery.

## Debrief — What a Strong Answer Looks Like

- HEARD in practice — Hear: let him show the photographs and finish, however long it takes. Empathize: 'this was your daughter's wedding and we damaged it' — name the actual loss, not 'the inconvenience'. Apologize: unconditional, no 'if' and no 'but'. Resolve: a concrete offer, now. Diagnose: the run-sheet gap, named to him as a real fix.
- What you are recovering is not the wedding — it is Mr Wong's standing. He chose this vendor and it failed in front of 200 guests including his extended family. The dignity loss is larger than the money.
- Setting the limit: never haggle. State the 40% as immediate and unconditional, then say you are taking the rest to the Director TODAY with your own recommendation, and give a time you will call back. Being on his side of the table is the move.
- Disclosing the known gap: strong arguments both ways. Disclosing shows honesty and makes the fix credible; it also hands him evidence of negligence. Most groups land on acknowledging a 'known process gap we failed to close' without the detail that it was flagged twice — accurate, honest, not self-incriminating. There is no single right answer here and the discussion is the point.
- Outcome is largely fixed (money is all that is left). But PROCESS and TREATMENT are entirely still in your hands — and research on perceived justice says those two often matter more than the refund amount.
- The fix: lock the run sheet against the live order record at print time, or block printing until amendments are closed. Then close the loop — tell Mr Wong what changed, in writing, a week later. That last step is what converts a detractor.

## Check Your Work

All five HEARD stages were delivered, your apology contained no conditional words, you set the 40% limit once without haggling, and you produced a written process fix with an owner.


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